



Building a computer in prison

A hacker built and hid a computer in the ceiling of his cell, and used it to access the prison systems. <https://digit.in/ghostinthecell>



Snap buys game engine

Snap, the company behind Snapchat has reportedly acquired a web based 3D game engine startup. <https://digit.in/snapengine>

kinds of “waking up” needs. Listening to a song or a station adds it to your library, so you can listen to it again, and scroll through them just as you would with a personal collections. Surprisingly for an international streaming service, the content is as regional as it can be. In fact, there is more focus on local content.

One of the biggest problems with JioMusic is how clumsy the interface is. You cannot even pause a song while searching for a new song, as the keyboard is overlaid on top of the playback controls. If there is a compilation album, the artist tag shows all the artists in the album for every track, so you have to use another app to even identify a song and the artist. There are no pure pop or rock playlists, these are bundled into stuff like christmas pop songs and rock love songs. The first song on the first playlist you get after searching for “Rock” is Chura Liya Hai Tumne. The good thing is that playlists are easy to identify as the number of tracks are listed. There is a wide variety available. In fact, we found some songs in the app that we could not find any trace of elsewhere on the internet. In any case, the collection seems to be expansive. There is even a dedicated section to K-Pop. While it is great to find the tracks that you like and listen to, the radio stations and playlists seem like they have been made 20 years ago, or earlier.



Regional languages

FEATURES

Streaming services have numerous additional features that allow us users to explore the full potential of a music-listening experience.

Starting off with something especially crucial to India, offline playback is found in almost all of the services mentioned so far. And almost all of them provide it exclusively to their paying customers. While Google Play Music lets non-subscribers buy individual tracks for download and offline

consumption, anything beyond that track is still at Google’s shuffled mercy.

Most of the music services offer multi-device support in some way or the other. If you are looking at just the ability to sign in on multiple devices, then after Spotify’s unlimited devices, Google Play Music comes in a close second at 10 devices (out of which 5 can be smartphones). While Gaana and Saavn are limited to 5 devices, Amazon Prime Music is also with Google at 10. But when it comes to simultaneous playback, the story changes. All 5 devices on Gaana and Saavn can stream their own music at the same time, whereas Apple Music and Spotify support 6 and 4 devices playing at the same time respectively under their family plan. Both Google Play Music and Amazon Prime Music officially support only one device per membership streaming music at the

same time, much like Spotify’s standard plan. The only difference here is, Amazon Music lets you complete the current song you’re listening to before prompting you to switch playback to other device or continue just on the current one. It needs to be known that signing into Amazon Music on any smartphone transfers the authorisation of that device to that particular account for the app.

So, to use any other account on that device after that within the next 180 days, you’ll have to contact Amazon customer care.

The social listening aspect is also common to both providers, and is almost exactly the same apart from, of course, Spotify’s add-ons like collaborative playlists. Spotify goes above and beyond this by providing features like private sessions (which is like an

incognito mode but for your music streaming), artist profiles, in-app lyrics and more.

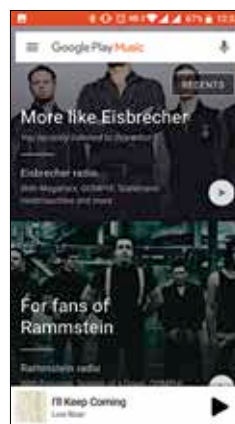
Amazon Music’s USP in this area is the availability of Alexa on the

app. In the Alexa section, you can talk to Amazon’s voice assistant in natural language, as long as you keep your queries music related. Interestingly, Gaana also offers a Gaana Assistant, which is similar but rudimentary compared to Alexa and can only directly search for terms you speak to it. For instance, when asked to play “something from the fifties”, both Alexa and Google managed to return

relevant playlists from the decades, but Gaana Assistant somehow managed to play “Something’s Wrong” from “Fats in the Fifties” on one occasion and a 90s mixtape on another. And out of all of these, only Google Assistant, enabled on the phone, responds without explicit activation using a button.

CONCLUSION

When it came to offering the best overall package, Gaana emerges as the winner, followed closely by Saavn. Both of these Indian platforms offer a good mix of free content and paid features, with Gaana beating Saavn by a small margin due to certain additional features and comparatively better scores in our performance tests. As of writing this comparison, news has come in that Jio Music is merging with Saavn, which comes as no surprise since the former scored the last position in our tests due to its limited offerings and carrier restrictions. While Google Play Music and Amazon Prime Music are big names in the music platform industry, their lack of ingenuity in features offered, coupled with sub-par support as compared to Indian platforms for regional music works against them. There you have it, Gaana is our winner! **d**



Google Play Music